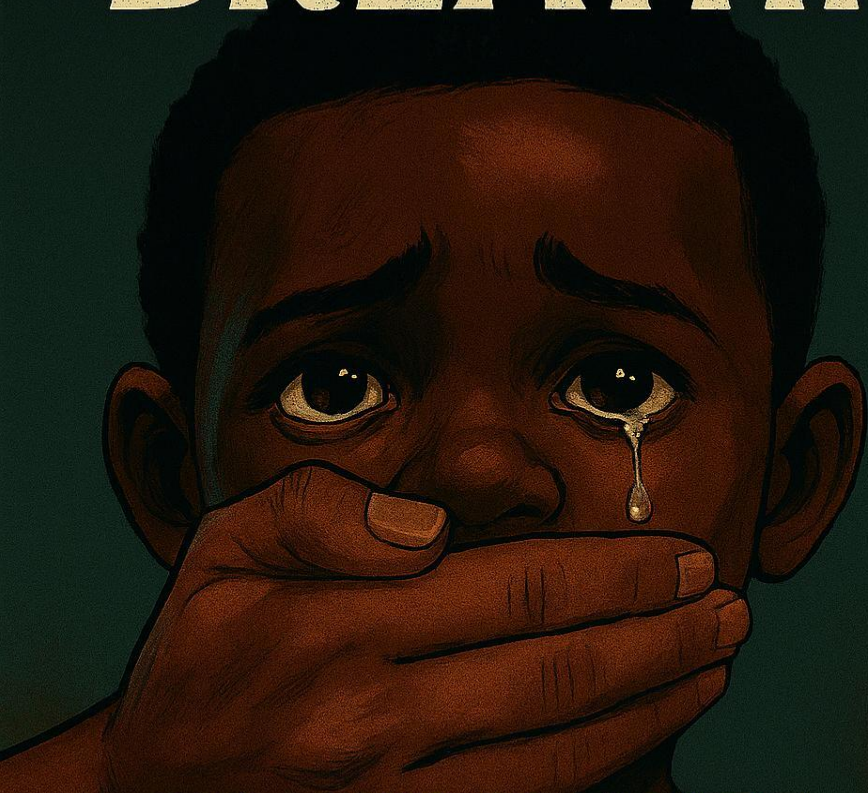


HIDDEN BREATH



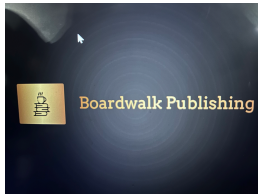
CLAYVON'TE
BROACH

A MEMOIR
(PART 1 OF 3)

CLAYVONTE BROACH

Hidden Breath

@Boardwalk_Clay



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To the Jones family—

*Especially to my stepdad Marcus Jones, his mother Mrs. Jones, and
to Marvin and Martha Jones.*

*Marcus, you taught me right from wrong, and those lessons shaped
the person I am today. Mrs. Jones, Marvin, and Martha, your
kindness and care left a lasting mark on my heart.*

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I want to take a moment to recognize and thank the people whose presence and support have meant so much to me.

To my mother, whose strength and love have carried me through more than words can ever capture.

To Londa, for standing by me and reminding me of the importance of family and loyalty.

To Shelby and her mother, for the kindness and care that touched my life in ways I'll never forget.

And even to Pig, because sometimes the smallest companions leave the biggest imprints on our hearts.

Your love, support, and presence have been a part of my journey, and I carry each of you with me in these pages.

Prologue

I was born into noise, into chaos, into a world where survival was never guaranteed but always demanded.

Flint was our beginning — a place that carved toughness into our bones and loyalty into our blood.

We were kids from Flint, and that meant we stuck together, no matter how hard the fights, no matter how heavy the scars.

From the start, my life was a collision of contradictions.

There was laughter and warmth, but also silence and dismissal.

There were moments of belonging, and moments of being forgotten.

There were scars that healed, and scars that never did.

I grew up in houses where adults played cards at the table while kids waged wars in the yard.

In laundromats where time stretched forever, and in corner stores where food stamps bought honey buns and granola bars.

In living rooms where Bible studies brought kindness once a week, and in bedrooms where secrets were buried under pillows and silence.

I learned early that pain was mine to carry alone.

That if I cried, I cried in secret.

That if I fought, I fought with everything I had.

And that if I survived, it was because I refused to let anyone

smother me — not with a pillow, not with silence, not with disbelief.

This is my story.

Of scars and laughter.

Of loyalty and betrayal.

Of being the outcast and the fighter.

Of being forgotten, and remembered.

Of breath taken, and breath reclaimed.

It is the hidden breath that carried me through.

And now, I'm ready to let you in.

Introduction

Every story I share in these pages is a piece of me — the child I was, the scars I carried, the laughter I found, and the battles I fought. Some memories are sharp, painful, and unforgettable. Others are wild, funny, and full of the chaos of growing up surrounded by siblings, cousins, and neighbors who shaped me. Together, they form the truth of my childhood: a truth that was messy, complicated, and unforgettable.

I write these chapters not to glorify pain, but to honor survival.

Not to dwell on what broke me, but to show how I kept breathing when it felt impossible.

Because every hidden breath I took — in fear, in laughter, in silence — carried me forward.

This memoir is about resilience.

It's about being a kid from Flint, tough and loyal, learning to fight back even when no one believed me.

It's about family — the warmth, the betrayal, the unity, and the chaos.

It's about the small moments that seemed ordinary at the time but became the stories I'll never forget.

You'll meet my siblings, my cousins, my mother, and the people who drifted in and out of our lives.

You'll see the games we played, the wars we fought, the dangers we survived, and the laughter that kept us alive.

You'll see me — not polished, not perfect, but raw and real,
the way I lived it.

I invite you to step into my world.

To walk through the laundromats, the corner stores, the card
tables, and the living rooms where these memories were born.

To feel the weight of silence, the sting of scars, and the joy of
small victories.

This is my introduction.

This is my truth.

This is Hidden Breath.

I

Part 1: Breath of Survival

The beginning grounds the reader in Flint, Michigan. These chapters capture the raw streets, the feeling of being an outcast, and the early battles that shaped my toughness. It's about survival in an unforgiving environment.

Chapter 1: Sticks in Flint

Flint was loud. Not in sound — in feeling.
The kind of loud that lived in your chest.
The kind that made silence feel suspicious.

I don't remember much about school back then.

Dort Elementary was a blur of brick and bell sounds.

But I remember the walk.

We carried sticks.

Not for fun. Not for show.

We carried them because dogs roamed like shadows.

Big ones. Fast ones.

And we were small.

It was me, my sister, and my brothers — a little tribe of survival.

We didn't ask questions. We just picked up sticks.

Like it was part of the uniform.

The sidewalk was cracked, the air was sharp, and every morning felt like a mission.

We'd march like soldiers, eyes scanning for movement, hearts

thudding like drumbeats.

Sometimes we saw them.

Sometimes they saw us first.

But we never ran.

We had sticks.

At home, the battles were real.

We didn't just argue — we fist fought.

Hard. Fast. Loud.

No referees. No rules.

I fought the most.

Not because I wanted to.

Because I had to.

My two middle siblings were a team — quiet, loyal, inseparable.

The oldest barely dealt with anyone but the second-to-oldest, and even that was rare.

Me?

I was the wild card.

The outcast.

The one who didn't quite fit into any pairing.

But when it came down to it — when someone messed with one of us —

We were a unit.

No matter how bruised we were from each other,

We had each other's back.

Mom made sure of that.

"You fight in here," she'd say,

"But out there? You ride for each other. No exceptions."

She didn't raise us soft.

She raised us ready.

Her voice could freeze a room.

Her belt could rewrite behavior.

We got whoopings like clockwork — swift, sharp, unforgettable.

But beneath every swing was a lesson.

A warning.

A kind of love that didn't come with hugs, but with survival.

Rubber band fights were our sport.

My big brother was a marksman.

One hand. No aim.

Bullseye every time.

I'd stretch mine back, squint, release — miss.

He'd flick his wrist — pop! — right in the neck.

I'd chase him through the house, duck behind the couch, reload from the junk drawer.

We turned the living room into a war zone.

Until Mom caught us.

Then it was over.

And the belt came out.

My father wasn't always there.

But he wasn't always gone, either.

He showed up in flashes —

Like lightning in a storm you didn't know was coming.

One of my earliest memories was riding home from school on his handlebars.

The wind in my face.

His hands steady on the grips.

Me, balanced between metal and memory.

But that wasn't the only time.

Sometimes he'd pop up with a gift — something random,
something loud.

A toy. A snack. A joke that didn't land but still made me laugh.

Sometimes he'd take me somewhere — just me.

And for a few hours, I felt chosen.

I didn't understand the gaps.

The silences.

The way he could disappear like smoke and reappear like
music.

But I held onto those moments.

Because they were mine.

Because they were real.

I didn't understand it then —

The fights, the sticks, the silence, the sting.

But now I see it.

We were learning to survive.

To defend.

To stand alone — and together.

And in that house, on those sidewalks, in those battles —

I was becoming me.

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Chapter 2: The Cold Move

We left Taylor Street in Flint with family woven into every block.
Cousins, aunts, uncles — familiar faces at every turn.

It felt like the city itself was stitched together with kinship.
And then, suddenly, we were gone.

From Taylor Street in Flint to Thomas Street in Grand Rapids.
The move wasn't just distance.

It was rupture.

It was stepping into a house that had no heat, no water, no welcome.

Just walls and silence.

I was five years old.

Too young to understand why the world had shifted,
but old enough to feel the bite of cold in my bones.

Nights stretched long, and the air inside was as cruel as the air outside.

My aunt would take a lighter and press its flame close to our hands and feet,

warming us one by one because the chill was unbearable.

That tiny flame became our furnace, our survival.

It was desperate.

It was real.

Some of our family came to help us move — Nasha and Peaches, carrying boxes, carrying hope.

Uncle Larry stepped in with money when we had none, his help like a rope thrown to the drowning.

And my cousin Londa was the only one who actually left Flint with us.

She brought her two kids — Kenny, two years older than me, and Dorisha, younger than me.

They were part of our new beginning, though it didn't feel like a beginning at all.

It felt like exile.

My siblings — Moya, Xerious, and Twaun — had their own rhythms, their own alliances.

Xerious and Moya stuck together like a team.

Twaun, the oldest, mostly kept to himself, only dealing with Xerious on rare occasions.

And me?

I was different.

I didn't want to be held.

I didn't want help.

Even at five years old, I carried myself like I had to stand alone.

Independent. Separate.

The outcast who refused to lean on anyone.

I fought the most.

Not because I was the strongest, but because I wouldn't bend.

I wouldn't let anyone carry me.

Every fist fight, every clash, every bruise was proof that I could

stand on my own.

That I didn't need an anchor.

That I was my own anchor.

Family had been everywhere in Flint, but in Grand Rapids, family was survival.

Every hand that helped, every flame that warmed, every dollar that saved us — it mattered.

But I learned early that survival wasn't about leaning.

It was about standing.

It was about refusing to break, even when the cold tried to shatter me.

We didn't have heat.

We didn't have water.

But we had grit.

And for me, that was enough.

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Chapter 3: The Dogpile

Beckwith Elementary was supposed to be a fresh start.
New classrooms, new faces, new rules.
But I didn't blend in.

I was too hyper, too restless, too alive.

The playground became my stage.

I flipped off everything — monkey bars, benches, the highest twisty slide.

I balanced on my head, stood on my hands, dared gravity to stop me.

Kids gathered just to watch.

I didn't get along with them, but I was popular.

Not because they liked me, but because they couldn't ignore me.

Teachers hated it.

They called my mom constantly:

"Your son is flipping off the slide again."

"Your son is upside down on the monkey bars."

"Your son is going to break his neck."

But I didn't stop.

I couldn't.
Then came the war.
Recess wasn't just playtime — it was battle.
We played war games, charging, defending, conquering.
But one day, a kid in a higher grade decided to test me.
He told my entire class to charge at me.
All of them.
At once.
They came like a wave.
Dozens of bodies crashing into mine, piling on top of me.
The weight was crushing.
I couldn't breathe.
I couldn't move.
I screamed for them to stop.
But they didn't.
They laughed.
They pressed harder.
And then something happened.
Something I still can't explain.
From the bottom of that dogpile, crying, desperate,
I felt a strength rise up from nowhere.
Hidden.
Buried.
But real.
I pushed.
I lifted.
And somehow, I threw them all off me.
Every single one.
I rose, fists swinging.
I punched two boys.
And then, blinded by rage, I turned on the girl I had the biggest

crush on.

I tried to gouge out her eyes.

The same eyes I used to stare at in class,
the same eyes that made me nervous when she smiled.

But in that moment, they were just targets.

They all ran away crying.

The war was over.

And I was the monster who won.

They told the teacher.

Every single one of them.

But somehow, I didn't get in trouble.

No detention.

No punishment.

Just silence.

And in that silence, I realized something:

I wasn't like them.

I wasn't meant to blend in.

I was meant to stand out — even if it was through chaos

II

Part 2: Bloodlines and Brotherhood

Here the focus shifts to family and sibling unity. These chapters highlight loyalty, mischief, and the unbreakable bond of the “kids from Flint.” The tension between hardship and love builds the emotional core of the memoir.

Chapter 4: The Price of Energy

The dog pile had made me infamous.
But my flips kept me untouchable.
Every recess, I was upside down, spinning, daring
the world to stop me.

The playground wasn't just a place to play — it was mine.

My stage. My arena. My proof that I was different.

I did backflips off the highest twisty slide, twisting through
the air like I was born to defy gravity.

I balanced on my head until the pressure made my skull ache.

I stood on my hands until my arms trembled, refusing to
collapse.

I thought it was strength.

I thought it was power.

But it was recklessness waiting to catch up with me.

And then it did.

The first spot appeared on my scalp like a warning.

I ignored it.

I kept flipping, kept balancing, kept pressing my head into the
dirt and concrete like it was a badge of honor.

But the spots multiplied.

Ringworm spread across my head like wildfire, a mark of my defiance.

It didn't stop with me.

Soon, my brothers and sister had it too.

Moya. Xerious. Twaun.

Each of them angry, each of them blaming me.

They didn't see the flips as freedom.

They saw them as carelessness.

They saw me as the reason they were suffering.

The house filled with frustration.

Every glare was a reminder that my energy had consequences.

Every complaint was proof that my independence came at a cost.

I had wanted attention, and I got it — but not the kind I craved.

Not the kind that made me feel powerful.

This attention was heavy.

It was shame.

The flips had made me popular at school.

Kids gathered to watch me, teachers called my mom in exasperation, and I stood out in every crowd.

But at home, the flips made me infamous.

I wasn't the hero of the playground anymore.

I was the villain of the house.

And yet, I didn't stop.

Even with the ringworm spreading, even with my siblings furious, even with the teachers warning me, I kept flipping.

Because the flips weren't just stunts.

They were survival.

They were proof that I couldn't be contained.

That I wouldn't be ordinary.

The price of energy was pain.

The price of energy was anger.

The price of energy was isolation.

But I paid it.

Every day.

Because I would rather be reckless than invisible.

Chapter 5: Family and Friends

When we first arrived in Grand Rapids, family was still close.

My aunts, Nasha and Peaches, lived with us in the beginning, their voices filling the house, their laughter softening the cold. Even without heat or water, their presence made survival feel less heavy.

And then there was Londa.

She wasn't just a cousin — she was constant. She came over all the time, bringing her two kids, Kenny and Dorisha. Dorisha was just a baby, her cries echoing through the house like fragile reminders of innocence. Kenny was older, two years ahead of me, and I admired him deeply. He seemed cool, adventurous, daring — almost like me. Most times, he matched my energy, and I looked up to him as proof that I wasn't alone in my wildness.

But family wasn't the only bond I found.

At Beckwith Elementary, I made my first real friend: Jamarco.

He lived just a block over, and I liked him immediately. His mom treated me like one of her own. She'd pick me up, buy me food, and sometimes even dressed us in matching outfits. For

a kid who often felt like the outcast, those moments mattered. They made me feel chosen, seen, part of something bigger than myself.

Between cousins and Jamarco, I felt a strange balance— part outcast, part chosen. Loved in flashes, independent in spirit, always searching for connection but never clinging too tightly.

Chapter 6: Scars and Rage

The ringworm had marked us all, but it didn't mark us equally.

My own scabs eventually healed, fading into faint reminders of recklessness.

But my sister's scars lasted longer.

Months, from what I recall.

Three bald patches where her hair refused to grow back, cruel reminders that no scarf could truly erase.

Every morning, my mother tied that scarf tight around her head before school.

It wasn't just fabric — it was armor.

It was protection against stares, whispers, and shame.

But armor only works if people respect it.

And kids at Beckwith Elementary didn't.

The older ones noticed.

They whispered, laughed, pointed.

They kept asking her what her head looked like under the scarf.

Their voices carried across the playground, sharp enough to cut through the noise and catch my attention.

I watched, tense, waiting for them to stop.

But they didn't.

One day, they went further.

They snuck up behind her, quick and cruel, and yanked the scarf from her head.

She froze, then bolted, running and crying, her hands clawing to cover the bald patches.

The laughter followed her like a storm.

One of the older girls pretended to console her, wrapping an arm around her shoulders.

But I saw the truth.

Her lips moved silently, mouthing words to the other kids, signaling, mocking, trying to expose my sister's head even more.

It wasn't kindness.

It was betrayal dressed as comfort.

And that's when it hit me.

A rage so sudden, so consuming, it felt like fire in my veins.

I charged.

I punched.

I fought everyone I could reach.

My fists flew, my body lunged, but they were older, stronger, heavier.

I couldn't do much.

But I didn't care.

I had to try.

I had to defend her

The playground erupted into chaos.

Shouts, cries, fists, laughter — all tangled together.

And then, like a shadow cutting through the storm, our mother arrived.

Her presence silenced everything.

She pulled us back, gathering us up, ending the fight with nothing more than her authority.

The ride home was quiet at first.

My sister sat beside me, scarf back in place, tears drying on her cheeks.

I sat restless, fists still clenched, the rage still burning inside me.

And then my mother spoke.

Her voice was steady, firm, but softer than I expected.

“You did good protecting your sister,” she said.

The words sank deep.

For once, my fight wasn’t just chaos.

It wasn’t just defiance.

It was loyalty.

It was proof that even as the outcast, even as the independent one, I could stand for something bigger than myself.

III

Part 3: Breath of Becoming

This section captures the turning point where survival transforms into self-definition. After the chaos, scars, and silence of childhood, Part III explores the moments of clarity that shaped independence, loyalty, and vision. It's about stepping beyond rage and abandonment into resilience — finding identity not just in struggle, but in the strength to build, invent, and honor the people who carried you forward.

Chapter 7: Forgotten

The ride home after the fight was quiet.
My sister sat beside me, scarf tied back in place, her
tears drying into silence.

I sat restless, fists still clenched, the rage still burning inside
me.

But my mother's words lingered:

"You did good protecting your sister."

For once, my fight wasn't just chaos.

It wasn't just defiance.

It was loyalty.

Her words wrapped around me like warmth, and for a moment,
I felt seen.

We pulled into the driveway.

The house loomed ahead, cold but familiar.

My siblings rushed inside, the day already fading into routine.

And then, I watched in confusion as my mother opened the
door to the house.

She stepped inside.

And she left me.

I was five years old, strapped into my seatbelt, staring at the door as it closed behind her.

I had no idea forgetting me was even possible.

Not her.

Not my mother.

But the silence told me otherwise.

I fought the seatbelt with everything I had.

My small hands clawed at the buckle, pulling, twisting, desperate to break free.

But it wouldn't release.

The strap cut into me like a reminder that I was trapped, helpless, forgotten.

Time slowed.

Minutes stretched into hours in my mind.

The silence pressed down heavier than the dogpile, heavier than the cruel laughter of kids at school.

I cried.

I cried so hard it felt endless, like forever was trapped in that car with me.

And crying was always my weakness.

Whenever I got angry, I cried.

I couldn't help it.

Every fight, every clash, every moment of rage ended with tears.

The crying always zapped the energy out of me, drained me, left me tired.

But this time was different.

This time, the crying consumed me.

It overwhelmed me until it was the last thing I remembered.

I cried so hard, so long, that exhaustion swallowed me whole.

And in the middle of my sobbing, I fell asleep.

When I woke, the world was softer.

My mother was there, apologizing, hugging me, her arms wrapping around me as if to erase what had happened.

But I knew.

I would never forget.

Because that day carved itself into me — proof that even in closeness, abandonment could arrive without warning.

Proof that independence wasn't just a choice.

It was survival.

Chapter 8: The Man Next Door

When my mother started dating Marcus Jones, the man right next door, everything shifted. I didn't understand what dating meant at five years old.

All I knew was that Marcus was around a lot, and his family was kind.

His last name being Jones, just like my mother's, felt strange, almost like fate playing tricks.

Marcus's mother treated me like I was her own.

She'd hand me food stamp bills and tell me to go spend them at the store.

She'd smile and whisper that I was her favorite.

For a boy who often felt like the outcast, those words mattered. They made me feel chosen.

But the person who stood out most was Marcus's niece — Pig. Pig liked us.

She liked my mother.

And she liked me.

I was only five, so it wasn't much of a crush, just a small flutter

I didn't understand.

I liked the way she smiled at me, the way she made me feel noticed.

It was innocent, simple, the kind of feeling that made me want to be around her more.

Marcus wasn't just a boyfriend to my mother — he was a bridge.

He introduced his friend Larry to my Aunt Peaches, and they hit it off.

He introduced his friend Bobby to my cousin Londa, and they hit it off too.

Suddenly, our family and theirs were tangled together, bonds forming in unexpected places.

But bonds didn't erase battles.

Marcus's sister Martha had kids around the same age as my brothers and sister.

And when the adults turned their heads, when laughter filled the living room, we slipped outside.

That's when the wars began.

We fought hard.

Not just play fights — real fights.

Punches, shoves, tackles into the dirt.

We were kids from Flint, and we carried that toughness with us.

Me, my brothers, my sister — we stuck together like a unit.

If one of us got hit, the rest charged in.

If one of us fell, the others pulled them back up.

We weren't just kids — we were a crew, hardened by where we came from, refusing to back down.

Kenny was there too, my cousin, my partner in wildness.

He matched my energy, reckless and fearless, and together

we led the charge.

The yard became a battlefield, every clash proof that we wouldn't be pushed around.

We fought until our knuckles burned, until our clothes were covered in dirt, until the adults finally noticed and pulled us apart.

But one day, the fight wasn't with Martha's kids.

It was with Marcus himself.

I was outside alone in the yard when he snuck up behind me.

He grabbed me suddenly, pretending to kidnap me.

I was only five — too young to know it was a joke.

Fear shot through me, so strong I peed my pants.

The humiliation burned, the terror stuck in my chest.

Later, Marcus sat on the couch with my mother, relaxed, laughing like nothing had happened.

But I couldn't let it go.

I walked up to him, small fists clenched, and hit him as hard as I could.

The punch landed so solid that for a moment, his reflex almost took over — his hand rising, ready to strike back.

But my mother grabbed his wrist, stopping him.

The room froze.

I stood there, trembling, but defiant.

I was only five, but I had made my point.

Even in fear, even in humiliation, I would fight back.

Chapter 9: Burn

The house was empty of adults.
No voices, no rules, no one to tell us what not to do.
Just kids.

It wasn't uncommon back then — our parents left us alone often, trusting we'd figure things out.

And most of the time, we did.

But hunger has a way of making kids reckless.

My stomach growled, the emptiness gnawing at me.

That's when Kenny stepped in, pretending to be the nice cousin.

He said he was going to show me how to cook noodles on the stove.

It sounded exciting — food, warmth, something to fill the silence.

Kenny always had a way of making things seem fun.

He joked, laughed, carried himself like he knew everything.

Even his farts — which always smelled like rotten eggs — became part of his legend.

We laughed, gagged, teased him, but it was all part of Kenny

being Kenny.

So when he said he'd teach me how to cook, I trusted him.

He filled a pot with water and set it on the burner.

The flame hissed, the water bubbled, steam rising into the air.

I watched, curious, believing him.

He was older, cooler, the cousin I admired.

If Kenny said he could cook, I believed it.

Then he told me to come closer.

He grabbed a fork — not a regular fork, but one of those long ones with two sharp prongs, the kind you'd use for a grill.

He dipped it into the boiling water.

The metal hissed as it came out, dripping, glowing with invisible heat.

Before I could understand, before I could move, he pressed it against my forearm.

The pain was instant.

White-hot, searing, cutting through me like fire.

I screamed, the sound tearing out of me, echoing through the empty house.

The fork didn't leave two prongs or a pattern.

It left a solid burn — a wide, angry scar that swallowed my skin in heat.

There were no adults to stop it.

No one to scold, no one to comfort.

Just kids, reckless and wild, testing boundaries we didn't understand.

I stared at the burn, tears streaming, the pain overwhelming.

And when I looked up at Kenny, expecting guilt or apology, I saw something else.

He was smiling.

Not the playful grin of the cousin who farted like rotten eggs

and made us laugh.

Not the smile of someone teaching me how to cook noodles.

It was menacing.

It was evil.

And it left me confused.

I didn't understand why.

I didn't understand how someone I admired, someone I trusted, could look at me like that after hurting me.

But the burn stayed, and so did the memory of that smile.

IV

Part 4: Breath of Legacy

This final part closes the journey by turning survival and becoming into something lasting. It reflects on how the lessons of childhood, the bonds of family, and the strength of invention evolve into a legacy that honors everyone who shaped the path. Part IV is about gratitude, permanence, and carrying the hidden breath forward — ensuring the story doesn't end with one life, but continues through the impact left behind.

10

Chapter 10: Silence and Study

Hidden Breath — Chapter 10: Silence and Study
After the burn, Kenny leaned in close and told me not to tell anyone.

And I didn't.

He was my big cousin, and I trusted him.

My family had always made me believe I should listen to people older than me, no matter what.

So I kept quiet.

I never told anyone what he had done to me.

In a way, I thought it was normal — something that just happened to people.

Time moved slowly after that.

Days blurred into weeks, weeks into months.

The burn healed, the scar softened, and eventually even the memory of what Kenny had done began to fade.

It was like the pain had been swallowed by silence.

I stopped thinking about it, stopped replaying it, stopped questioning it.

Kenny was still around, playful as ever, farting like rotten eggs, laughing, pretending like nothing had happened.

And I let myself believe it hadn't.

Part of me forgot because forgetting was easier.

But part of me forgot because I had learned something else as a child:

My mother always seemed to get angry when I got hurt.

It didn't matter if it was an accident, a fight, or a scrape from playing too hard.

Her frustration came fast, sharp, like my pain was my fault.

So I stopped telling her about my injuries.

At a young age, I learned to keep them to myself.

Cuts, bruises, burns — they became secrets I carried alone.

Life carried on in its rhythm.

My whole family had always been Jehovah's Witnesses.

Even though my mother was heavily off into the ways of the world, she still made sure the Witnesses stopped by once a week to give us Bible studies.

Every week, without fail, they came.

They were the kindest people I had ever met.

Gentle voices, patient lessons, smiles that felt safe.

For that one hour, the house felt different — calmer, lighter, almost holy.

One of the women had a daughter named Shelby.

She was around my age, and she seemed to like my wild company.

I was loud, restless, always moving, but Shelby didn't mind.

She laughed at my energy, followed me around, and for a moment, I felt like I had a friend who saw me for who I was.

Her presence made the Bible studies feel less like lessons and more like belonging.

And through it all, Kenny was still there.

As playful as ever.

Joking, laughing, carrying himself like nothing had ever happened.

Pretending the burn didn't exist.

Pretending he hadn't pressed that fork against my arm.

And I stayed silent.

Because he was older.

Because he was family.

Because silence had already become my survival.

Chapter 11: The Mustache Lady

Hidden Breath — Chapter 11: The Mustache Woman
Max 10 was one of our favorite places to shop.
Everything in the store was ten dollars or less, and for my mother, that meant possibility.

For me, it meant adventure.

Every trip, I turned the store into my playground.

I'd dart between aisles, crawl into clothing racks, and disappear into my makeshift jungle gym.

Inside those racks, I felt hidden, untouchable, listening to my mother's voice echo across the store as she called my name.

I'd hear her get close, her footsteps circling, and then — at the perfect moment — I'd burst out at full speed, running directly into another rack.

It was my game, my thrill, my way of turning shopping into chaos.

When my game was finally up, I'd answer her call with a drawn-out "hmmmmm?"

That was my signal.

And she'd deliver a string of curse words to drag me back to

her side.

It was routine, almost ritual.

But one particular day, the game ended differently.

I came flying out of a rack, head down, charging into the open space — and slammed directly into the rear of a woman I had never seen before.

The impact froze me.

My mother saw it happen and rushed to apologize on my behalf.

Her face flushed, her voice quick, embarrassed.

I looked up at the woman, confused, and saw something I had never seen before.

She had a mustache.

Not faint, not hidden — a real mustache.

My five-year-old brain couldn't process it quietly.

I stared into her eyes and said exactly what I saw:

"You have a mustache!"

The words hung in the air like a siren.

My mother's voice cut through immediately, sharp and unmistakable:

"Vonte!"

Whenever she said my name like that, I knew I was in trouble.

Her tone carried weight, warning, and embarrassment all at once.

But the woman didn't lash out.

She smiled.

She seemed understanding, almost amused, as my mother feverishly apologized, trying to smooth over the moment.

The tension broke, replaced by awkward laughter.

We left the store, my mother still giggling, still embarrassed.

She shook her head, replaying the moment, half-mortified,

half-amused.

And that story stuck.

She told it to her friends for the rest of my life.

She still does.

Chapter 12: The Pillow

The laundromat always felt like forever. Machines hummed, clothes spun, and time stretched long while we waited.

Londa was there with her two kids, living right above the place in an apartment connected to the same building.

It was like she belonged to the rhythm of the washers and dryers.

For us kids, the laundromat meant one thing — the racing game.

Four steering wheels, four cars, all tearing around the track.

I was always good at video games.

No matter what we played, I beat everyone.

Even Kenny, who hated to lose more than anything.

Every time I crossed the finish line ahead of him, he'd slam the wheel, shout, and storm off.

His temper was part of the game, but it never changed the outcome — I always won.

When the laundry was done, we headed back to Thomas Street.

That house was our anchor.

From there, we'd walk around the corner to the little store we were allowed to visit without adults.

It felt like freedom, like we were trusted to roam.

I always had food stamps from Mrs. Jones tucked in my pocket, ready to spend on honey buns and granola bars.

Sweetness and crunch — my treasures from the corner store.

Back home, the adults gathered at the table, playing cards and talking like they always did.

Their laughter and arguments filled the room, a steady backdrop to our games.

And we started our own — hide and seek.

My sister was "it."

She turned to the wall, closed her eyes, and began to count to ten.

Her voice echoed through the room as we all scattered, running to hide in different corners, behind furniture, under blankets.

I watched everyone dart away, my mind racing for the perfect spot.

Then I saw it — a large couch pillow.

I laid down on the floor, tucked my legs between blankets, and pulled the pillow over my body and face.

In my mind, I was invisible.

No one could see me.

I was hidden.

At first, it worked.

I lay there, quiet, waiting, listening.

But then I felt something.

A force pressing from the other side of the pillow, pushing it down against my face.

At first, I laughed.

I thought it was a joke, another kid trying to mess with me.

But the pressure didn't stop.

It lasted longer and longer, heavier and heavier.

The air thinned, my chest tightened, and panic surged through me.

This wasn't a game anymore.

I was being smothered.

I couldn't breathe.

I thrashed beneath the pillow, my arms clawing, my legs kicking, desperate to break free.

The blankets tangled around me, trapping me even more.

My lungs screamed for air, my body jolted with fear.

I needed to get up.

I needed to survive.

The laughter in my head was gone.

All that remained was the terror of suffocation, the realization that I was powerless unless I fought harder than ever before.

And in that moment, the same determination that made me unbeatable in video games — the same fire that drove me to beat Kenny every time he played — surged through me.

I pushed, twisted, kicked, and finally broke free, gasping for air, my chest heaving, my body trembling.

The game of hide and seek had turned into something else entirely.

And I would never forget the feeling of fighting for breath beneath that pillow.

Chapter 13: Smothered

Under the pillow, the air thinned fast.
I was running out of breath, running out of time.
Panic surged through me, sharp and overwhelming.
First, I tried to push them off.
My small arms strained, but they were too strong.
The weight pressed harder, sealing me in darkness.
Then I tried yelling.
“I can’t breathe!”
But my words were swallowed by the pillow, muffled into nothing.
No one heard.
No one came.
Tears welled up, hot and uncontrollable.
And with the tears came my last stand.
I fought.
I punched, kicked, scratched with everything I had.
My body thrashed in desperation, every move fueled by the terror that this might be my last breath.

My lights were about to go out.
Then — the scratching started to work.
I could feel it.
The grip loosened.
I clawed harder, more furious, more frantic.
And suddenly, I was released.
I shot up, gasping, frantic, my chest heaving.
I didn't look back to see who had been on top of me.
I didn't care.
I ran straight to the table full of adults, tears streaming down
my face, crying, desperate to explain what had just happened.
But they didn't believe me.
Or maybe they weren't listening.
My words fell flat, dismissed before they even landed.
I'll never forget that moment — the way they brushed me off,
the way they didn't take me seriously at all.
It made me cry harder.
It hurt deeper than the smothering itself.
Because now I was alone.
Alone with a killer in the house.
Alone with no protection.

Conclusion

This story is not over.
What you've read here is only the beginning — the first breaths of a life shaped by chaos, survival, and silence.

Every scar, every laugh, every dismissal has carried me forward, but the journey continues.

There are moments I still don't fully understand.

Like the night of the pillow.

I never saw who was on top of me, never knew whose hands pressed down as I fought for air.

I only knew the terror, the panic, the frantic scramble to survive.

And I only knew the silence that followed — the way my cries were dismissed, the way my truth was ignored.

For years, that memory lived inside me as a question mark.

A shadow without a face.

A killer in the house, unnamed, unacknowledged, unpunished.

CONCLUSION

But time has a way of revealing what silence tries to bury.

And in Part Two, the truth comes out.

The mystery of the pillow is confirmed.

The shadow gains a name.

And the story deepens into something even more haunting,
even more necessary to tell.

So this is not the end.

It is only the close of the first breath — the hidden breath that
carried me through childhood.

The next breath, the next chapter of my life, waits just beyond
these pages.

Epilogue

Childhood ended, but the lessons never did.

The scars I carried from Flint, from Thomas Street, from the laundromat and the corner store, stayed with me.

They shaped the way I saw the world, the way I trusted, the way I fought.

As I grew older, I learned to channel that fire into something more.

Into invention, into business, into storytelling.

Every fight, every dismissal, every hidden breath became fuel for resilience.

I built things — ideas, organizations, stories — because I knew what it meant to survive without protection.

I knew what it meant to rely on myself.

The games we played, the laughter we shared, the dangers we survived — they became the foundation of who I am today.

And though the child in me was often silenced, the adult in me refuses to be.

That's why I write.

That's why I build.

That's why I breathe.

The story of Hidden Breath is not just about the past.

It is about the legacy of survival, the transformation of pain into purpose, and the determination to leave behind something

greater than scars.

Afterword

Writing this memoir was not easy.

Every chapter pulled me back into moments I thought I had forgotten, or wished I had.

But telling the truth matters.

Because silence protects no one.

Because hidden breath deserves to be heard.

I wrote this for the child I was — the boy who fought under a pillow, who cried at the card table, who laughed in clothing racks, who survived in silence.

I wrote this for my siblings, my cousins, my family — the kids from Flint who carried toughness in their bones.

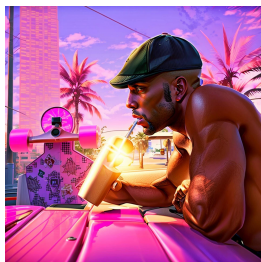
And I wrote this for anyone who has ever felt dismissed, unheard, or unseen.

Thank you for walking through these memories with me.

Thank you for listening to my truth.

This is only the beginning.

The story continues in Part Two.



About the Author

Clayvon'te Broach is a survivor, a builder, and a storyteller. Before becoming an author, he lived a life forged in struggle and resilience. From the streets of Flint, Michigan, where toughness was a necessity, to enduring and overcoming prison time, Clayvon'te carried those experiences as fuel for transformation.

He worked as a lumberjack, mastering the strength and discipline of the trade, and became a professional longboarder, channeling balance, speed, and freedom into his craft. Each chapter of his life reflects perseverance against the odds, a refusal to be broken, and a determination to rise.

Today, Clayvon'te stands as an author, telling his story with raw honesty and cinematic detail. His journey is proof that even from the hardest beginnings, greatness can be carved, balance can be found, and a voice can emerge that refuses to be silenced.

You can connect with me on:

 <https://www.facebook.com/clayvonte.broach.2025>

